to better-equipped hospitals in Naypyitaw or Yangon, or provide office space for local neighbourhood funeral associations.

One key example of the synergistic relationship between welfare-oriented social action and religious institutions in central Myanmar is the role played by 'Byama-so', a national funeral association and welfare group founded by monks in Mandalay and now closely tied to the Free Funeral Service run by Myanmar film actor Kyaw Thu. The Taungoo chapter of Byama-so was formed in 2002 with the support of a local monk in response to perceived local profiteering in funeral services. In turn, the patrons for the organization — a broad cross-section of Taungoo's local business elites, civil servants, and even senior Burmese armed forces commanders — provided funds to purchase vans, employ drivers, and construct a new crematorium. Within months of the formation of the entirely Buddhist management committee and the opening of the organization to volunteers in 2002, the cost of basic funeral services was brought down to around US$20 for some small expenses, including fuel and a processing fee, though these expenses are apparently waived entirely for families unable to afford them.[6] As of mid-2015, the organization conducted between forty and sixty funerals each month, with over 600 funerals being assisted by the organization across the township in 2014.

The role of Byama-so as one of the primary township-level arenas of social work in Taungoo was solidified in 2006 when the organization established an offshoot chapter adjacent to Taungoo General Hospital with the support of an elderly local cigar merchant. The social support offered by the organization subsequently expanded beyond its core work in funerals, providing services that supplement the local government-run hospital, including an ambulance service as well as management of a blood bank with over 4000 donors across Taungoo's diverse communities, and sale of discounted oxygen tanks for patients suffering from breathing difficulties. With political liberalization since 2011, Byama-so has retained its centrality in welfare delivery for the town, despite rapid growth in social spending under President Thein Sein's decentralization initiatives. Hundreds of people now engage on a weekly basis in various forms of *parahita* with the organization, including driving funeral cars and ambulances, doing office and paper work, participating in chanting as part of funeral processions, and donating blood for patients at the hospital. One volunteer even helps the widows of former government servants to ensure their spouses' pensions are transferred to them as the entitlement guidelines permit.